

Letter of Intent — Scholarship Application

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I was a computer engineering student at the University of Tehran when I was dismissed for cultural and political activity. I started again from zero, in civil engineering elsewhere, and went through years I still find hard to talk about, as many Iranians of my generation have. What I took from it, long before I had the words: the space you are allowed to think in is drawn by someone, and doing well inside it does not protect you from its edges. A santur helped me through; I have played it for over twenty years.

Everything since has been a way of learning how spaces are made. I wrote control software for substations, led construction and infrastructure projects for a decade, worked with galleries, artists and architects, and for four years built machine-learning systems people rely on daily — forecasts that decide what a store orders, classifiers that alert project teams, agents that draft what decision-makers read. They worked, and quietly moved the question *what counts?* out of sight, into a feature set I had written. That is what information architecture means to me: where the decision about what counts is made, and by whom.

Two questions will not leave me. The first is creativity — what it is, technically, philosophically, and for a person. I have followed generative systems and their artists since ChatGPT's first day, and keep arriving at one unease: most celebrated AI art samples a space rather than transforming it. I may be wrong, and want to find out properly; but if the machines through which we imagine can only sample, we will all live inside the average.

The second is civic. I was in the streets during the Mahsa Amini uprising, and in Iran on 8 and 9 January 2026, when thousands were killed in forty-eight hours under an internet blackout. A blackout is information architecture as a weapon. Kavian, the design inquiry I have worked on since — an evidence-first, anti-capture platform where every claim is typed, sourced and answerable — is not an attempt to take power but to give it back: the power to know what is happening to you.

Norbert Wiener is the thinker I return to, for his warning against handing judgment to machines with frozen objectives; Stafford Beer taught me to ask of any system, artwork or state what it actually does. Healthcare is where I test these ideas, the one domain where AI seems to work *for* people: I am second author on a 2026 *JDCS* study of federated versus centralized LLMs at the surgical edge, and am finishing an M.Sc. in Data Science in Berlin.

I am not a philosopher but a builder who has run out of the vocabulary his questions need, and The New Centre is the only place I know that treats them as one field. Its reading of intelligence as technique and screen for power, the Intelligence Design Lab's building with agentic tools while questioning them, and the seminars of Morgane Billuart, Vincent Lê, Anna Longo and Simon Schirren are the conversation I have been looking for. I bring two decades of building things that had to work, and a life that has felt what information architecture does.

I am requesting a full scholarship. I am an Iranian student in Berlin covering my own living costs without family support because of Iran's situation; I already hold a training scholarship here. Without full support I honestly cannot take part. With it, I will give this everything, and the certificate's final essay will be this research's first public statement.

With gratitude,

Kaveh Momeni